

CHAPTER 14 — The Flight

“Day seven,” Zoe said, “is today.”

Elias glanced at her in the mirror, then returned his attention to the motorway.

The late-afternoon light had turned the fields beyond the barrier the colour of old brass. It softened the pylons, service roads and backs of warehouses without improving any of them.

“Take me through the morning,” he said.

Zoe looked down at the backpack between her feet.

At midnight, Jackie still had not called.

Zoe sat on the bedroom floor with the spare phone connected to its charger and the volume turned as high as it would go. The screen dimmed twice. Each time she touched it awake, half expecting the movement to summon the call.

Nothing.

At twelve fifteen, she sent no message.

That had been the rule.

No calls. No warnings. No second attempt that might reveal where Jackie had gone or who was waiting for her.

The house had become very quiet.

Helen moved once along the landing and stopped outside Zoe’s door. The floorboard gave its usual soft complaint beneath her weight. She remained there long enough for Zoe to see the shadow beneath the gap, then walked away without knocking.

At one, Zoe carried the phone downstairs.

Helen sat at the kitchen table in her cardigan, both hands wrapped around a mug she was not drinking from. Brian stood at the back door with the curtain lifted by one finger.

“She hasn’t called,” Zoe said.

Neither adult asked who.

Helen looked at the phone.

"What time was she meant to?"

"Before eleven."

Brian released the curtain.

"She may have gone home."

"She promised."

"She is thirteen," he said. "Thirteen-year-olds miss calls."

"Not Jackie."

Helen set the mug down.

"Zoe—"

"The route is exposed."

The words altered the pressure in the room.

Brian looked towards the hallway, as though the sentence might have been heard through the walls.

"You don't know that," Helen said.

"We agreed. No call means I don't travel."

"You and Jackie agreed."

"Yes."

"Mac arranged this before Jackie came here."

"That doesn't make it safe."

"It is already arranged."

Zoe stared at her.

Helen heard what she had said only after saying it. Her expression changed, but she did not take it back.

Brian crossed the kitchen and removed the phone from Zoe's hand.

She reached for it.

He held it away.

"Mac said no personal devices."

"That's mine."

"It can be tracked."

"So can the car."

"Enough."

He pulled the charger free, switched the phone off and put it in his pocket.

For one second Zoe considered screaming.

Jackie had told her to make noise. Break something. Run to a neighbour. Make it impossible to move her quietly.

The front door was locked and chained. Brian stood between her and the back door. Helen was already crying, though no tears had fallen yet.

Outside, somebody's security light came on across the gardens.

Zoe looked towards it.

A fox moved along the top of a wall and disappeared.

There might have been people beyond the hedge. There might have been a car at the end of the road. There might have been nothing at all.

Jackie had left the house wearing Zoe's coat and carrying a false route.

She had not called.

The house was no longer shelter. It was only the last known place in a plan that had failed.

"Give it back," Zoe said.

Brian kept the phone in his pocket.

"You need to sleep."

"I need to know where she is."

"We don't know."

"Then call the police."

Helen looked at Brian.

Brian looked away first.

That was the answer.

Zoe returned upstairs without permission.

She locked the bedroom door and dragged the desk chair beneath the handle.

The backpack waited under the bed where she had hidden it.

She pulled it out, placed it on the duvet and opened the numbered folder.

The paper smelled dry and old.

The first page held the photograph she had seen in Cain's house: herself at six or seven, hair in two plaits, laughing at something outside the frame.

Beneath it was a number.

The same number appeared on the archive label, the property bag Cain's people had used for her belongings and every page that followed.

There were dates.

Locations.

Medical notes written in language that treated her body as a set of tolerances.

A name she did not recognise appeared beside the word Origin.

Her own name appeared later beneath a heading marked Assigned

identity.

Zoe read the line three times.

The room seemed to draw away from her.

She turned the page.

There was a payment record.

The amount meant nothing. It was too large to resemble pocket money and too precise to resemble a gift. A reference number sat beside it.

Below that was another field.

Authorising client.

Mac's legal name appeared beside it.

Not uncle.

Not guardian.

Not family representative.

Buyer.

A second document named Helen and Brian as the Receiving placement. Their address was correct. The transfer date was months earlier than the adoption date Zoe had been told all her life.

There was no adoption order.

No court.

No social worker.

Only a transfer, signatures and a continuing payment schedule.

Zoe's hands began to shake.

She pressed them flat against the paper until they stopped.

On the shelf above her desk, the photographs remained where they had always been. Helen on the beach. Brian fighting with a tent pole. Jackie leaning into frame behind a birthday cake.

The room was full of evidence that a life had happened.

The folder did not say the life had been false.

It said it had been purchased.

That was worse.

A sound came from the landing.

Zoe closed the folder, slid it beneath her exercise books and placed the black hard drive at the bottom of the backpack. She still did not know what the drive contained. She knew only that adults had fought over the archive and that Cain's people had built layers of security around it.

The handle moved against the chair.

"Zoe?" Helen said.

Zoe zipped the bag.

"What?"

"We need to leave in three hours."

"I'm not going."

A pause.

Then Helen said, "The car is coming at four fifteen."

"Jackie didn't call."

"I know."

The answer was so quiet Zoe almost missed it.

She moved the chair and opened the door.

Helen stood in the hallway holding a small pile of clothes. Her face looked older than it had at dinner. She had tried to fold Zoe's jumper and failed; one sleeve hung almost to the floor.

"What does Mac know?" Zoe asked.

Helen looked at the clothes.

"He knows the arrangements have to happen quickly."

"That isn't what I asked."

"I don't know what he knows."

"Did he say Jackie's name?"

"No."

"Did he ask about her?"

Helen's eyes lifted.

"No."

That frightened Zoe more than if Mac had known everything.

He had arranged the flight without knowing the decoy existed.

If Cain's people had been watching the house, Mac had either failed to see them or had never known they were there. Jackie had disappeared somewhere between two systems, each moving Zoe for reasons it refused to explain.

Helen held out the clothes.

"Please get dressed."

"I am dressed."

"For the flight."

"I said I'm not going."

Helen's mouth trembled.

"Staying here is not safe."

"Going where Mac tells me isn't safe either."

"I know."

The admission escaped before Helen could stop it.

They stood facing each other in the narrow hallway.

For the first time, Zoe saw the full shape of Helen's failure.

Not that she felt nothing.

Not that every bedtime story and packed lunch had been an act.

Helen loved her. Helen was frightened. Helen knew Mac's plan might be wrong.

And Helen was still going to help carry it out.

"What happens if I refuse?" Zoe asked.

Helen looked towards the stairs.

Brian was below them, out of sight but listening.

"I don't know," she said.

"Yes, you do."

Helen folded the jumper again.

This time the sleeve stayed in place.

Zoe did not sleep.

She changed into clean clothes because the school uniform had already carried her through one escape and she did not want it used to identify her again. She kept the same trainers. They were scuffed, familiar and quiet.

At three forty, she packed the few ordinary things Helen had placed on the bed: underwear, a toothbrush, a spare top, the photograph of Elias and the travel documents.

She added the folder and hard drive beneath them.

The backpack was the only bag she took.

No suitcase.

Nothing that would need to be checked in.

Nothing she could not run with.

She remembered Jackie's instructions.

Scream.

Break something.

Run to a neighbour.

Make quiet removal impossible.

Zoe stood at the bedroom window and looked through the narrow gap in the curtains.

The street appeared empty.

That meant nothing.

Staying would leave her inside a locked house controlled by people who refused to call the police. Running into the street might lead directly to whoever had taken Jackie. The flight belonged to Mac, but movement might create places where Mac's control weakened: a terminal, a gate, an aircraft, another country, a collector she had not yet met.

Movement was danger.

Movement was also the only opening she had left.

She was not agreeing that the route was safe.

She was choosing the part of it that might still give her a door.

At four ten, Brian removed the chain from the front door.

The sound travelled through the silent house.

Helen stood beside Zoe in the hallway. She had made tea and forgotten to drink it. Brian wore his coat but no shoes, as if part of him still believed he was not participating if he did not step outside.

Headlights moved across the curtains.

A dark car stopped at the kerb.

No horn.

No engine revving.

The driver did not come to the door.

Zoe tightened both straps of the backpack.

Helen reached for her, stopped, then tried again.

This time Zoe did not step back.

Helen held her with the same real, desperate strength she had used when Zoe returned home two nights earlier.

"I'm sorry," she whispered.

Zoe stood inside her arms.

"For what?"

Helen's breath caught.

There were too many answers.

She gave none of them.

Brian opened the door.

Cold air entered the hallway.

Zoe stepped outside.

At the gate she looked back.

Helen stood beneath the unlit porch lamp with one hand over her mouth. Brian had already begun closing the door.

Neither followed her to the car.

The driver wore a dark coat and kept both hands on the wheel.

He did not introduce himself.

When Zoe asked his name, he said, "I'm taking you to the airport."

"That isn't a name."

He looked at her once in the mirror and did not answer again.

The city was barely awake. Delivery lorries occupied the main roads.

Street-cleaning vehicles moved through empty junctions with amber lights turning silently on their roofs. At bus stops, small groups of workers stood beneath shelters, shoulders raised against the cold.

Every ordinary person they passed felt impossibly available.

Zoe could have opened the door at a red light.

She could have run towards a petrol station or banged on the window of the car beside them.

She kept seeing Jackie beneath the orange alley light, raising two fingers against the dark.

The true route might belong to whoever had stopped her calling.

But the house belonged to Mac.

The car he had arranged was moving Zoe away from the street she believed Cain's people had watched. The flight would take her beyond Helen, Brian and every adult whose instructions had already failed her.

Zoe sat back and memorised the route to the airport.

A woman met them outside Departures.

She wore the navy coat, flat shoes and neutral lanyard of a private airport meet-and-assist service. A clear plastic folder rested beneath one arm.

The driver handed her Zoe's travel documents.

He did not say goodbye.

The woman checked Zoe's face against the passport, then looked at the backpack.

"Is that all?"

"Yes."

"Did you pack it yourself?"

Zoe tightened her grip on the straps.

"Yes."

The woman smiled without warmth.

“Keep it with you, then.”

Inside, the terminal was bright enough to erase the hour. Cleaning machines moved across polished floors. Coffee kiosks were opening. Recorded announcements repeated instructions nobody appeared to hear.

The woman guided Zoe towards a separate check-in queue.

Every question had already been answered on paper.

Who was she travelling with?

Nobody.

Who was meeting her?

A named adult with identification.

Did she have permission to travel?

The woman placed a signed consent form on the counter. It carried Helen’s recorded guardian details and a signature Zoe recognised.

Where was she staying?

An address had been entered.

The system did not ignore Zoe.

It processed her perfectly.

That was the frightening part.

A check-in agent smiled and placed a small sticker on the back of Zoe’s boarding pass.

“Big journey on your own.”

Zoe looked at the woman beside her.

“She’s used to travelling,” the woman said.

It was a lie delivered in the tone of a fact too dull to question.

The agent accepted it.

At security, Zoe removed her trainers and placed the backpack in a tray.

The black hard drive passed through the scanner beneath a jumper and two schoolbooks.

For the length of the conveyor belt, it was beyond her reach.

Zoe watched it enter the machine.

The woman watched Zoe.

When the bag emerged, Zoe took it before putting her shoes back on.

"You'll need to be calmer at the other end," the woman said.

"Why?"

"The man collecting you has been told you've had a difficult week."

"What else has he been told?"

The woman adjusted the folder beneath her arm.

"That you're upset."

"Did Mac tell you to say that?"

The woman's face did not change.

"Your gate is on the lower level."

She walked Zoe as far as passport control.

Beyond it, only passengers could continue.

The woman handed her the folded photograph of Elias, though Zoe already had another copy inside the backpack.

"This is the man meeting you."

"I know."

"He will identify himself. You will go with him."

“Where?”

“To the address on your instructions.”

“My grandmother’s.”

“That’s correct.”

“What’s her name?”

The woman looked at the documents, though the answer should have been simple.

Then she closed the folder.

“Do exactly what your uncle arranged.”

She left before Zoe could ask anything else.

Nobody stopped Zoe at the gate.

That was when the fear changed.

Until then she had been waiting for Cain’s people to appear from behind a pillar, seize the backpack or drag her into one of the anonymous corridors staff used between public spaces.

They did not.

The gate opened.

Passengers formed a queue.

Zoe boarded.

From her window seat she watched service vehicles cross the wet tarmac. Baggage carts moved between aircraft. A man in a reflective jacket raised two illuminated batons and guided another plane backwards.

Everything happened according to signals.

Nothing moved until someone authorised it.

The aircraft began to taxi.

Zoe kept the backpack beneath the seat in front of her, one shoe

pressed through the strap.

As the runway lights accelerated beside them, she thought of Jackie's missing call.

Jackie knew the pickup time.

The airport.

The flight.

The arrival terminal.

The photograph of Elias.

The false-grandmother address.

If somebody had forced the route from her, they knew those things too.

The aircraft lifted.

The city fell away beneath cloud.

Zoe waited for relief.

It did not come.

She remained awake through the flight.

A cabin attendant offered her a blanket. Zoe refused it.

A meal arrived in a foil tray. She ate the bread roll and left everything else untouched.

Across the aisle, a man slept with his mouth open beneath an eye mask. Two rows ahead, a child complained that the window shade had to remain raised. People read, watched films and shifted in their seats as though the aircraft were nothing more than an inconvenient room between two ordinary days.

Zoe unfolded Elias's photograph on her lap.

The image showed a man with short dark hair, a tired face and no obvious reason to fear him.

On the back, Mac had written:

He is harmless. Do exactly what he says.

Zoe read the sentence until the handwriting became shapes.

Mac had chosen someone who looked harmless.

Someone who would not ask why a thirteen-year-old travelled alone.

Someone who would deliver her to an address because that was the job.

If the true route was exposed, nobody needed to stop the aircraft.

They only needed to know where it would land.

The flight removed Zoe from the one person she trusted, from the streets she understood and from every neighbour who might recognise her name. At the far end, she would become a photograph on a stranger's phone and a destination entered into a sat-nav.

One collector.

One car.

One route.

Isolation disguised as protection.

Somewhere between countries, Zoe decided she would not reach the grandmother's address.

She did not yet know whether Elias worked for Mac, Cain or neither of them.

It did not matter.

The first moment he left her alone, she would run.

"He sent me your photograph," Zoe said in the car. "Mac had written that you were harmless."

Elias let out a quiet breath through his nose.

"Flattering."

"He meant controllable."

The humour left his face.

"He sent me yours," Elias said. "Told me you'd recognise me and it would help you trust me."

"It helped me identify you."

"Not the same thing."

"No."

The motorway curved through a cutting. For several seconds, concrete walls rose on both sides and held the engine noise close around them.

"If they had the route, why let you board?" Elias asked.

"Because the flight did the work for them."

"How?"

"Jackie didn't call. The route was in her head. Nobody tried to stop the car, the escort or the flight. Then Cain's lieutenant found us on the route towards the address before it could reasonably have been chance."

Elias kept his eyes ahead.

"They knew you," Zoe continued. "They knew the arrival time and the direction. Once you collected me, identifying the car was easy."

"The flight isolated you."

"It delivered me to one man."

"And if that man had done what he was told?"

"I would have reached the address."

The answer remained between them.

Zoe looked down at the backpack.

"There's one more thing."

Elias did not prompt her.

"I opened the folder before the car came."

His eyes moved to the mirror.

"It was mine," she said. "Not just records from the house. Records from before Helen and Brian."

"What kind of records?"

"My photograph. A number. Another name listed as my origin. Medical notes. Payments."

Elias adjusted his hands on the wheel, placing them precisely at either side.

"There was a field marked Authorising client," Zoe said.

The words became harder as they approached the truth.

"Mac's legal name was beside it."

Elias looked at her in the mirror for longer than the road allowed, then faced forward again.

"Are you certain?"

"It was the name Helen used on Christmas cards when she thought writing 'Mac' looked rude."

"What about Helen and Brian?"

"Receiving placement."

The phrase sounded worse spoken aloud.

"There was a date months before the adoption date they gave me. No court papers. No adoption order. Just a transfer and payments."

Elias felt his face settle. He kept both hands in the same position on the wheel because changing anything would reveal how completely the information had altered the job.

"He isn't my uncle," Zoe said.

"No."

"He bought me."

The road opened beyond the cutting. Late sunlight flooded the windscreen.

"Helen and Brian didn't adopt me," she said. "They received me."

Elias drove in silence.

"He sent you because he needed somebody who would bring me back without asking what I was being brought back to," Zoe continued.

"Somebody outside Cain's world. Somebody ordinary."

"Harmless."

"Yes."

A road sign appeared ahead, listing the grandmother's exit and the distance remaining.

Elias read it.

Zoe's theory about why Mac had chosen him was plausible.

It was not complete.

Mac had known enough about Elias to keep using him and little enough—or pretended little enough—to send a child into his care without warning him what followed her.

"You were right about one thing," Zoe said.

"What?"

"You aren't harmless."

The sign drew closer.

Elias's indicator remained silent.

"No," he said. "I'm not."

The exit lane began beside them.

"What happens now?" Zoe asked.

Elias looked towards the slip road, then past it.

"Now we don't go to your grandmother's." Zoe turned fully towards

him. "Where do we go?" The exit fell behind them. Elias met her eyes once in the mirror. "Somewhere he doesn't know to look."